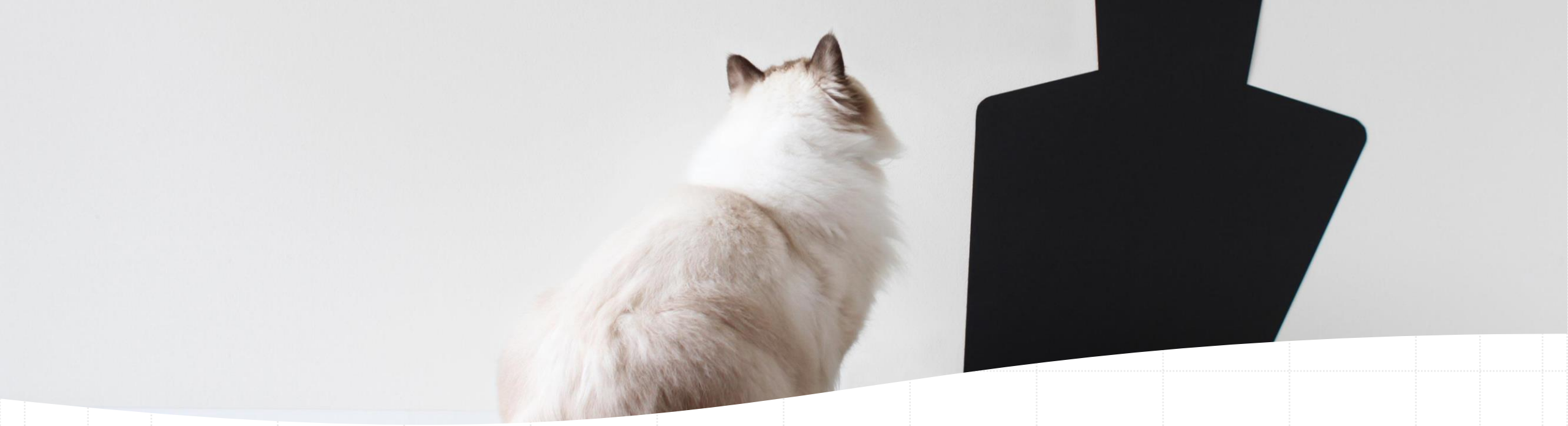


Equity, Diversity & Anti-Oppression

Implications For Embodied Intimacy Coaching

Kai Cheng Thom, MSW, MSc, Qmed, SSE



WHAT BRINGS YOU TO THIS WORK OF INTIMACY COACHING?

- What is an important value or ideal that led you to becoming a coach?
- What is the potentially harmful side of that ideal?

Engaging Complexity

by Kai Cheng Thom(c)

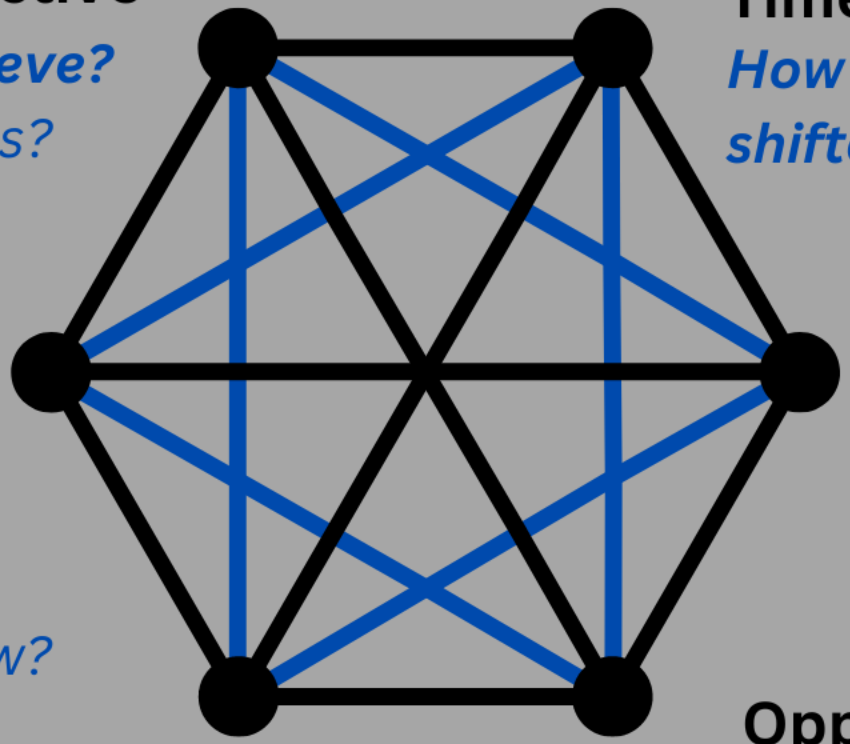
Your Perspective

What do I believe?

What's my bias?

Time

How has this issue shifted over time?



Sources of Knowledge

What informs us?

Culture, science, religion, media etc

Unknown & Unknowable

What am I missing? *What can I never know?*

Place

How does location affect this issue?

Opposing Perspectives

What do they believe?

What's their bias?



“If you have come here to help me you are wasting your time, but if you have come because your liberation is bound up with mine, then let us work together.”

– Lilla Watson & Queensland Aboriginal Rights Group

Historical Context of Diversity In Coaching

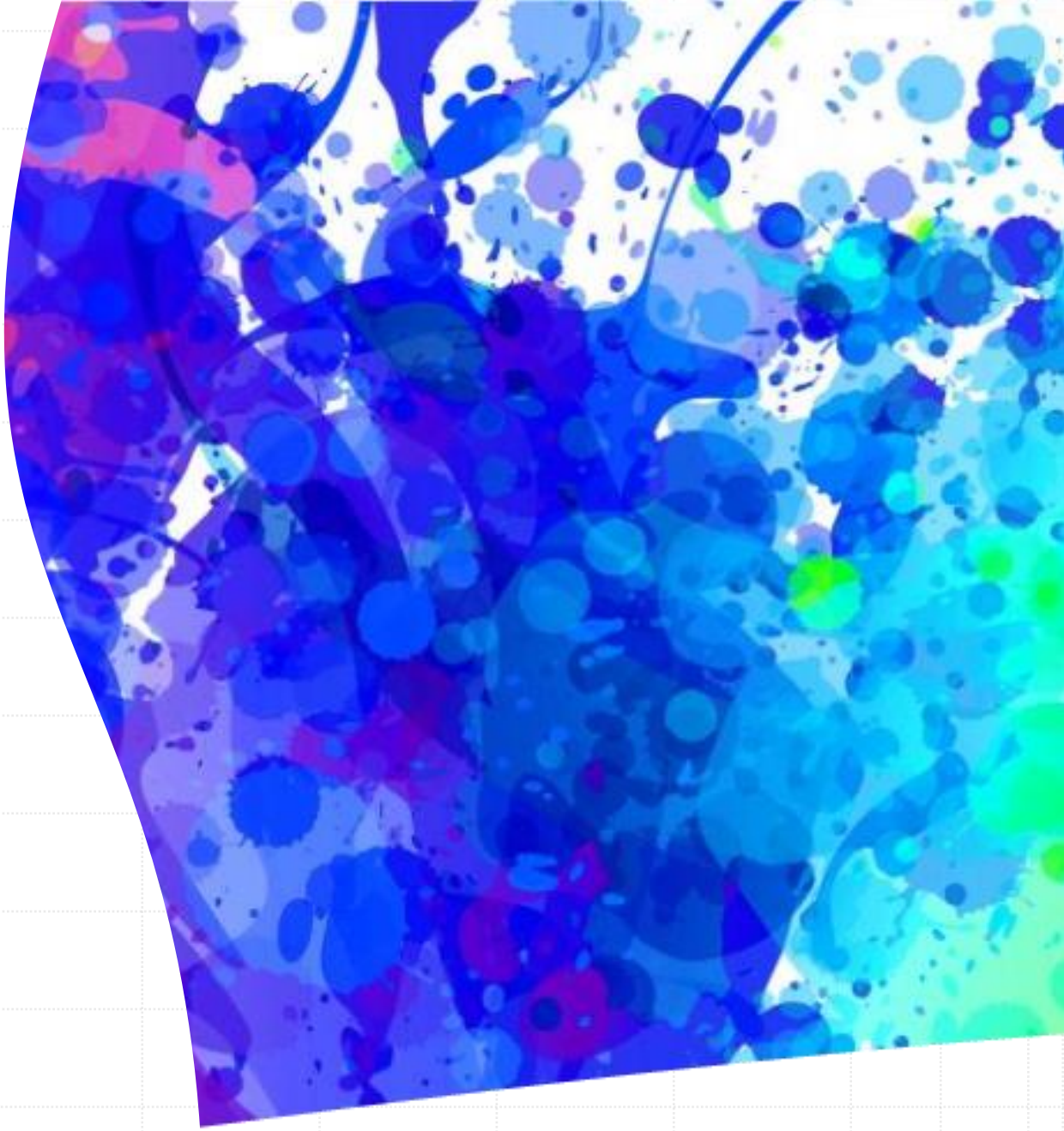
An equity, diversity, and anti-oppression perspective acknowledges that social work, healthcare, and psychiatry/psychology are neither inherently good nor neutral. While the helping professions provide essential services to communities, they also play an instrumental role in creating, maintaining, and enforcing social norms and power dynamics. Many such professions are directly responsible for carrying out social atrocities, including but not limited to:

- The cultural genocide of Indigenous peoples, ie The Sixties' Scoop and ongoing child "welfare" practices that disproportionately target Indigenous and other racialized communities
- Eugenics and enforced sterilization of disabled people, eg Alberta Eugenics Board
- Medical experimentation and exploitation of Black and other racialized peoples, e.g. Tuskegee Syphilis Study
- Pathologization of LGBTQ2S+ individuals and the practice of conversion therapies

As a relatively new helping profession, coaching does not carry the same weight or legacy as others. Yet we must remain alert, aware, and conscious of the potential to do harm in our work. The majority of mainstream coaching curriculums and ethical standards include little or no awareness of the context of colonization or oppression.

“History is not the past. It is the stories we tell about the past. How we tell these stories – triumphantly or self-critically, metaphysically or dialectally – has a lot to do with whether we cut short or advance our evolution as human beings.”

– Grace Lee Boggs



THE ROOTS OF OPPRESSION

By Kai Cheng Thom©



THREE PILLARS OF DOMINATION

by Kai Cheng Thom



THE FRUITS OF FREEDOM

By Kai Cheng Thom©



Understanding Sexual Oppression

by Kai Cheng Thom©

Sexually Valued

Sexually Objectified

I am perceived as attractive by the dominant culture, though my pleasure comes second if at all

My access to sexual choice & voice is limited at best, I am likely to receive unwanted erotic attention and touch

Sexually Privileged

I am perceived as attractive & deserving of erotic pleasure by the dominant culture, my erotic self is validated by those around me

I have access to sexual choice & voice, I am empowered by society to say "no" to sexual interactions I don't want

Low Access To Sexual Agency/ Consent

High Access To Sexual Agency/ Consent

Sexually Marginalized

I am perceived as repulsive by the dominant culture, but I am also heavily fetishized as a taboo sexual interest

I am likely to experience a high level of unwanted erotic attention while also having my erotic self reviled. Partners may try to hide or harm me as a result of the stigma of being with me

Sexually Invisibilized

I am perceived as unattractive & undeserving of erotic pleasure by the dominant culture

Society empowers me to say "no" to unwanted sexual attention, but not to say "yes" to my own desire, because my erotic self is likely to be shunned & reviled by those around me

Sexually Devalued

COLLECTIVE TRAUMA, MORAL INJURY & CONFLICT IN THE HELPING PROFESSIONS

Members of an oppressor class, or perpetrator groups, tend to experience collective trauma that their group is responsible for as a threat to identity that can be destabilizing or even debilitating. Individuals can respond with a variety of strategies, including denying, minimizing, or dis-identifying with the perpetrator group (Hershberger, 2018)

Moral injury is a wounding of the psyche and the spirit that occurs when we are forced or tricked into witnessing and/or participating in an act or multiple acts that are in violation of our personal and collective values. This can be as a specific kind of trauma that happens when our understanding of goodness in ourselves and the world around us is damaged. (Nash, 2013)

Effective collective trauma healing contains the elements of “truth and reconciliation,” but also accountability – telling the story and filling in missing information, accounting for loss and owning the harm (Audergon, 2004)



TREE OF CULTURAL EROTIC GROWTH

By Kai Cheng Thom, Somatic Sex Educator

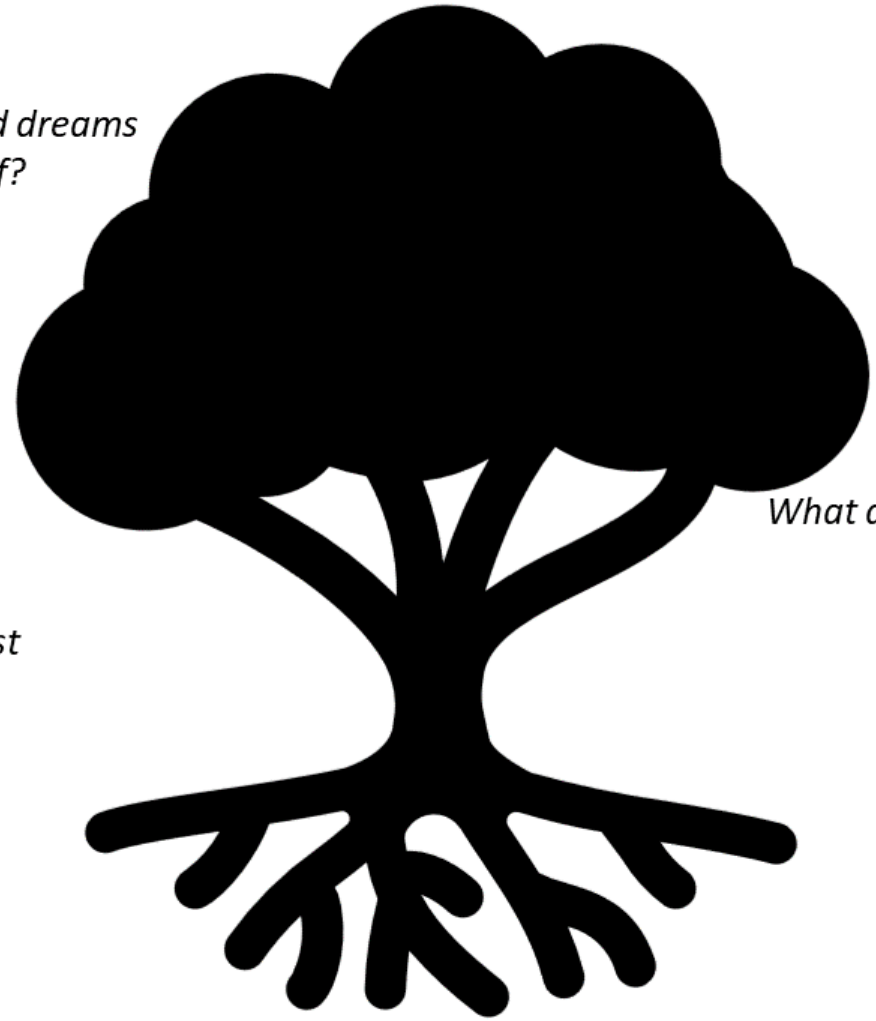
LEAVES

What are my hopes and dreams for my erotic self?



FRUIT

What gifts do I want to leave for generations to come in regards to ideas about race, culture, and sexuality?



BRANCHES

What does my cultural erotic self or shape look like now?

TRUNK

What are the life experiences that have most informed my erotic experience as a living body?



FALLEN LEAVES

What cultural and/or racist ideas about sexuality do I want to let go of?

ROOTS

What are the cultural lineages and forces that have shaped my erotic development? For better and for worse?

Inspired by the Narrative Therapy "Tree of Life"